

Channel Vision

It takes a village as these Madhya Pradesh tribals show by digging their own canals from the nearby Indravati river



FARMERS DIGGING ONE OF THE CANALS

By Ambreesh Mishra

It's a nondescript nook in tribal Madhya Pradesh, but what local farmers have done here is a giant step in self-reliance. Two small canals built by farmers in Jhagadi village in Khargone district are testimony to what determination can achieve. On the western fringes of the state bordering Maharashtra, the Nimar region's long, dry summers have been the bane of its agrarian economy for years. But the tribal farmers of Jhagadi village were determined to turn things around.

The opportunity came in September last year when a committee was formed by a quasi-government body, the MP Jan Abhiyaan Parishad (MJAP), to build a bund on the Indravati river that flows near the village. The bund would hold water that would then be pumped into the fields. The alert villagers immediately recognised the devil in the details. Pumping water would mean steep power or diesel costs. They decided to go in for the one-time, cheaper option of digging canals. But that was easier said than done. Since the village is within a reserved forest area, using the forest land was impossible as the

procedure involved taking permission from the Centre.

The villagers then planned to route the canals through their own land and steered clear of the forest area. Many farmers gave up some portion of their land for the greater common good of the village. The forest village, typically spread across the river, now boasts of two canals, one emerging from each of its banks. The two canals, 3.5 km and 1.5 km-long respectively, irrigate the fields of 27 farmers. Sushil Barua, district coordinator of MJAP says: "The villagers did all the technical assessment regarding the slope of the land and contours for digging the canal themselves and everything was achieved through voluntary labour." That the tribals are community-oriented has not only facilitated honest efforts to build the canals but also in sharing the water equitably.

The results of reliable and regular supply of water are visible. Bhuman Singh Dabar, the 27-year-old Varela tribal head of the committee, says: "The rabi crop output this year was better than ever." This is a do-it-yourself story that has made one village very proud. ■